

Designing the Environment

Ask Yourself

1. **Values & Co-Creation:** What two or three core values do you want your classroom environment to convey, and how are your students involved in bringing those values to life through co-creating the space, establishing expectations, and labeling materials?
2. **Purposeful Zones:** Walk through your classroom mentally. Do you have a space for collaboration, quiet independent work, and calm? For any zone that's missing, what is one simple design change you could make this week?
3. **Flexible Seating:** Think about a student who struggles to stay focused during carpet or seat work. What barrier might their seating be creating — core strength, need for movement, need for space — and what is one flexible seating option you could introduce to remove it?

Activity

1. **Space Audit:** Draw a quick sketch of your classroom and label each area with its current purpose. Then walk through it as if you're a student arriving for the first time — can you find your name, your seat, and where your belongings go? Identify any missing zones (collaborative, quiet, calm corner, gathering space) and sketch where each could live with what you'd need to create it.
2. **Flexible Seating Trial:** Choose one student who struggles with seating — on the carpet, at their desk, or both. Observe them for one focused work period and note specifically when seating becomes a barrier. Introduce one flexible seating option and reflect on whether it changed their engagement.
3. **Build the Space Together:** Designate one area as your collaborative space and one bulletin board or display to co-create with students. For the collaborative space, add at least two supports like a teamwork anchor chart, labeled roles, or a talking tool, and introduce it during morning meeting. For the display, draft the language you'll use to invite students in — an "under construction" sign, an open invitation, or a labeled placeholder — and plan how you'll build it together in the first few weeks.

Community and Connections

Ask Yourself

1. **Knowing Every Child:** Can you identify at least one genuine interest, strength, or detail about each child's life outside of school? Does every child hear their name spoken with care by an adult before they settle into the day? Which students do you know least well, and what's one way you could change that?
2. **Co-Created Community:** Think about your classroom agreements or norms. Were they co-created with students or decided by you? How would your students describe the values of your classroom community?
3. **When Things Go Wrong:** When conflict or disconnection happens, do students have the language, tools, and structures to make amends, or does resolution depend entirely on you?
4. **Connection Mapping:** If you mapped the friendships in your classroom right now, which students would have strong mutual connections and which might be on the edges? What is one intentional step you could take to help a less connected student move from new to known?

Activities

1. **Know Them Before and Early:** Create one resource — a short video, picture book, or meet the teacher guide — that introduces your classroom to incoming students before the first day. Include a question or two for families to discuss together. Then in the first two to three weeks, sit with each student individually during play, snack, or arrival and have a casual conversation covering interests, family, hobbies, and how they handle hard moments. Keep a simple note of what you learn for each child.
2. **Co-Create Your Class Charter:** In the first week, work with students to define how you want your classroom to feel and how you will treat each other. Record their words in a visible document that lives in the classroom all year. Revisit it when the community needs a reset and add to it as the community grows.
3. **Map the Relationships:** Over one week, observe free play, centers, and arrival and note who gravitates toward whom, who plays alone, and who moves between groups. Map what you find visually and use it to inform your partnering decisions and identify any child who needs more deliberate support. Revisit monthly.
4. **Teach Making Amends:** Using a read aloud or neutral scenario, explicitly teach accountability and repair. Give students sentence stems, practice together, and post the language somewhere visible so students can reference it independently when the real moment comes.

Transitions

Ask Yourself

1. **Challenging Transitions:** Which transitions in your day tend to unravel most often — and when you picture the students who struggle most, what barrier is likely driving it? Is it sensory overload, a need to move, difficulty holding multi-step directions, or something else entirely?
2. **Predictability and Executive Function:** Walk through one of your trickiest transitions mentally. How much of the success of that transition depends on students remembering what you said versus having a visual or physical cue to guide them? What is one support you could add this week to reduce that cognitive load?
3. **Choice and Emotional Readiness:** Think about a student who consistently arrives back from recess or lunch dysregulated. What is the transition asking of them emotionally, and what is one proactive design choice — a quiet activity, a movement option, a predictable routine — that could help them land more successfully?

Activities

1. **Transition Mapping:** Map out a typical day and identify every transition, noting who struggles and why. Use the transition mapping template to brainstorm one UDL-aligned strategy for each pressure point. If working with colleagues, share your maps and compile the strategies that are working into a shared resource.
2. **Observe and Build:** Observe one transition in your own or a colleague's classroom and take notes on what works and what breaks down. Use what you notice to create one visual support — a checklist, a step-by-step poster, or a schedule — for your most challenging transition. Share it with a colleague for feedback before putting it into practice.
3. **Transition Makeover:** Choose your most challenging transition and give it a full redesign using the UDL strategies from this chapter. Plan for the predictable barriers, introduce it to students, and reflect after one week on what changed. Bring your results to your next PLC.

Reflection

Ask Yourself

1. **Reflection Audit:** When do you currently build in time for reflection, and where are you missing opportunities? Think about specific students — who lacks vocabulary, who needs movement, who would benefit from visuals? Pick one missing moment in your day, one student barrier, and one strategy to address both this week.

2. **Deepening the Practice:** Which type of reflection — formulaic, situational, deliberate, or dialectical — do you use most often, and which would stretch your practice? What would it look like to intentionally plan for one deeper level of reflection this month?
3. **Making Growth Visible:** How do you currently help students see their growth over time? If portfolios, photo documentation, or revisited work samples aren't yet part of your practice, what's one simple, sustainable way you could start capturing student progress in just one subject area?
4. **Your Own Reflection:** Dewey wrote that we learn not from experience but from reflecting on it. Do you have routines for thinking about what worked, what didn't, and why? How might modeling your own reflection process help students understand why this skill matters?

Activity

1. **Build Your Reflection Toolkit:** Create a collection of reflection supports you can use across your day — 5-7 age-appropriate reflection questions, 3-4 sentence stems, visual aids like emotion faces or activity icons, and 2-3 movement-based options. Then map your weekly schedule and identify two or three moments where you could drop one in. Choose one moment and one support and commit to trying it for two weeks.
2. **Create a Reflection System:** Choose one system from the chapter — reflection drawers, a 1-3 finger scale, photo documentation, or your own design — gather materials, teach it to students, and use it consistently for one week. At the end of the week reflect on what worked, what needs adjustment, and how students responded.
3. **Make Growth Visible:** Begin a simple portfolio process in one subject area and plan at least one deliberate "change over time" experience — comparing early and recent writing samples, revisiting photos from the first week, or watching videos of themselves from earlier in the year. Facilitate a reflection conversation and document what students notice about their own growth.

Small Group Instruction

Ask Yourself

1. **Reflection Audit:** When do you currently build in time for reflection, and where are you missing opportunities? Think about specific students — who lacks vocabulary, who needs movement, who would benefit from visuals? Pick one missing moment in your day, one student barrier, and one strategy to address both this week.
2. **Deepening the Practice:** Which type of reflection — formulaic, situational, deliberate, or dialectical — do you use most often, and which would stretch your practice? What would it look like to intentionally plan for one deeper level of reflection this month?
3. **Making Growth Visible:** How do you currently help students see their growth over time? If portfolios, photo documentation, or revisited work samples aren't yet part of your practice, what's one simple, sustainable way you could start capturing student progress in just one subject area?
4. **Your Own Reflection:** Dewey wrote that we learn not from experience but from reflecting on it. Do you have routines for thinking about what worked, what didn't, and why? How might modeling your own reflection process help students understand why this skill matters?

Activity

1. **Build Your Reflection Toolkit:** Create a collection of reflection supports you can use across your day — 5-7 age-appropriate reflection questions, 3-4 sentence stems, visual aids like emotion faces or activity icons, and 2-3 movement-based options. Then map your weekly schedule and identify two or three moments where you could drop one in. Choose one moment and one support and commit to trying it for two weeks.
2. **Create a Reflection System:** Choose one system from the chapter — reflection drawers, a 1-3 finger scale, photo documentation, or your own design — gather materials, teach it to students, and use it consistently for one week. At the end of the week reflect on what worked, what needs adjustment, and how students responded.
3. **Make Growth Visible:** Begin a simple portfolio process in one subject area and plan at least one deliberate "change over time" experience — comparing early and recent writing samples, revisiting photos from the first week, or watching videos of themselves from earlier in the year. Facilitate a reflection conversation and document what students notice about their own growth.

Reflection

Ask Yourself

1. **Your Small Group Presence:** What percentage of your attention goes to your small group versus monitoring the rest of the class? How much does your current structure honor students' need to talk and move? Which students might thrive with more partner work or movement, and what would it take to shift your focus toward deeper engagement with your small group?
2. **When Independent Work Falls Apart:** Think about a recent time independent work broke down. Which barrier was at play — unclear expectations, uninteresting tasks, finishing early? What feels exciting about offering a buffet of choices to address that barrier, and what feels overwhelming? What's one small step toward more flexibility?
3. **Your Teacher Tools:** When do you find yourself using the look, the tone, or the name mention most during small group time? What might it mean if you're relying on them constantly versus rarely?

Activities

1. **Observe and Diagnose:** Set up small group time but don't pull a group. Instead observe for 10-15 minutes without intervening, noting what students do well, where they get stuck, and what surprises you. Use the Predicting Barriers framework to identify which specific barrier is most present, then brainstorm two or three practical solutions using the strategies from this chapter. If working with colleagues, share observations and diagnose together.
2. **Build Your Buffet:** Choose one subject area and design three May Do options aligned to your current learning goals, varying format across tech and no tech, solo and partner, creative and practice-based. Then choose one option you haven't tried yet like This or That, TeachTok, or another from the chapter and teach it explicitly to students, try it, and document what worked and what needs adjusting.
3. **Co-Create Visual Expectations:** Draft an anchor chart showing what small group time looks like and sounds like from both the student and teacher perspective. Include what students will be doing and what the teacher will be doing. Introduce it to students before your next small group session and revisit it when expectations need a reset.

Emotional Literacy

Ask Yourself

1. **Emotional Vocabulary and Empathy:** Review the last few days. What emotions have you heard students name, and what have you observed them experiencing but lacking words for? Choose two or three emotion words to teach this month. Then think about a recent conflict between students. What empathy skill could you explicitly teach to help them navigate similar moments more successfully, recognizing facial expressions, considering another's perspective, or using empathetic language?
2. **Your Own Regulation:** Think about a recent moment when you felt dysregulated in your classroom. What strategy did you use or wish you had used? How might naming your feeling and strategy out loud model the very skills you are trying to build in your students?
3. **Audit Your Structures:** Review a typical instructional block and count how many minutes students spend in passive listening versus active engagement. Then evaluate your calm corner. Can students access it independently and do they know how to use what is inside? Identify one built-in engagement strategy to embed in your block and one small improvement to your calm corner to make this week.

Activities

1. **Teach Emotion Words:** Choose two or three emotion words beyond happy, sad, and mad that would benefit your students. For each, write a kid-friendly definition, identify a book character or scenario that demonstrates it, and connect it to a body sensation. Introduce one word this week during morning meeting or a read aloud. Then co-create an anchor chart with students about big feelings and what to do with them, using both words and pictures so every student can access it independently.
2. **Build Your Calm Corner Toolkit:** Audit your calm corner using three components: tools to name feelings, a menu of strategies, and physical comfort items. Add one missing element. Then teach or re-teach students how to use the space, including one breathing technique like bunny breath or smell the flower, blow the candle, practiced together during a calm moment two or three times over the week. If you don't yet have a calm corner, designate a space and gather materials this week. Post a visual of the breathing technique so students can use it independently.

3. **Embed Engagement and Teach the Brain:** Choose one lesson where students typically lose focus and embed one built-in engagement strategy from the chapter. Teach the protocol explicitly, use it two or three times over the week, and reflect on whether it prevented dysregulation. Then during a separate calm moment teach students the Flip Your Lid hand model using kid-friendly language and practice using that language consistently when you notice students becoming dysregulated.

Centers

Ask Yourself

1. **Centers Through Student Eyes:** Walk around and look at your centers through the eyes of each student. Is there something here for everyone? Whose interests are not yet represented and how could you weave them in? Then identify the center that has lost its spark. What might be keeping students away, the work, the space, or the materials?
2. **Engagement Audit:** When you observe center time, are students deeply engaging or rotating quickly without completing tasks? Stand in your most challenging center right now. Would a student know what to do without asking you? What one support could you add today?
3. **Structure and Values:** Does your current center structure, rotational, choice-based, or a combination, align with your values around student agency and variability? What is driving your current structure and is that still the right reason?

Activities

1. **Center Audit:** Create a simple chart for each center with four columns: Center Name, Type (place-based, materials-based, interest-based, floor-based, table-based, movement-based, digital), Barriers Addressed, and One Thing I Could Change. Then sit in your classroom and think through each student one at a time. Is there something here for them? Would they know what to do? Is there a center that would light them up that doesn't exist yet? Use both the chart and the student lens together to make one change this week.
2. **Strengthen One Center:** Choose a center students frequently avoid or ask for help with. Add one layer of support, a visual direction card, a help card, a task card, or a short video. Then give it a quick makeover using the Keeping Centers Fresh strategies, swapping materials, adding a new tool, or rotating something stored away. Reintroduce

it using the Discovery and Inquiry approach and observe whether engagement increases over the following week.

3. **Try a New Structure:** If you currently use a purely rotational model, try giving students choice for one center time. Set up a system to manage popular centers, a complete a task before rotating expectation, and a visual system for open spots. Reflect afterward on how students responded, what worked, and what barriers came up that you hadn't anticipated.

Arrival and Morning Routines

Ask Yourself

1. **Your Arrival Story:** How have your own experiences with morning routines shaped your current approach? What unique aspects of your classroom or school environment could you leverage to make arrival more intentional and welcoming?
2. **Flexibility and Belonging:** How can you make arrival time flexible enough to support students who struggle with separation or big emotions, while still building a sense of belonging for every student from the moment they walk in?
3. **Learn from a Colleague:** What does arrival look like in a colleague's classroom on your grade level or the grade level above or below? What is similar, what is different, and what is one thing you could borrow or share?

Activity

1. **Map and Visualize Arrival:** Observe arrival from a student's perspective, mapping the path from the door to their designated area and identifying points of confusion. Then create a visual schedule using photos, drawings, or clip art for each step of the routine. Display it at student eye level, practice walking through it together, and add any arrival station visuals like a backpack drop spot or choice board that would help students move independently.
2. **Support Big Feelings and Separation:** Design a feelings check-in system using emotion faces, colored cards, or drawing materials, and plan how you will explicitly teach students to use it. At the same time gather a small collection of transitional objects and school-only distractions like soft toys, sensory items, or a rotating arrival job such as watering plants or feeding a class pet, so you have options ready when a student needs support getting through the door.
3. **Design Morning Choice Time:** Plan what independent choice time looks like after students complete their arrival routine. What activities will you include? Aim for variety across quiet independent work, movement, cooperation, and fine motor skills so every kind of learner has somewhere purposeful to go.

Commented [AU2]: link to visual schedule and feelings check in resources

Morning Meeting

Ask Yourself

1. **Honest Look at Your Practice:** Which elements of your current morning meeting were designed intentionally with barriers in mind, and which have just always been done that way? Where are students with long sitting times, attention challenges, or language needs underserved by your current structure?
2. **Voice, Choice, and Language:** In what ways could you incorporate more student voice and choice into your morning meeting? How could you embed language development more intentionally, through sentence stems, visual supports, or structured partner sharing, without losing the community feel?
3. **One Next Step:** What is one specific UDL-aligned strategy from this chapter you will try in your next morning meeting? What barrier is it addressing and how will you know if it helped?

Activity

1. **Map Your Morning Meeting:** Take your current structure and for each of the four parts list one or two barriers you notice in your practice. Then brainstorm one UDL-aligned support to address each barrier. Use the chart from this chapter as your starting point.
2. **Redesign and Support Language:** Think about how sharing currently happens in your morning meeting and redesign it to include movement, visuals, or choice. As part of that redesign create sentence stems for your most common prompts, would you rather, what's your favorite, how was your weekend, so every student has a way in. Try it and tag me @edtech_jeff with what you notice.
3. **Add Time and Visual Support:** Take your most recent morning message and revise it with multiple means of representation, colors, symbols, images, highlighted words, or a suspenseful fill in the blank. Then identify one moment in your morning meeting where students would benefit from think time and add a structure like think-pair-share, a wait timer, or a visual reminder of choices. Try it for one week and note what changes.

Calendar

Ask Yourself

1. **Purpose and Barriers:** What are the actual mathematical goals driving your current calendar time? If you had to name them, could you? Which predictable barriers from this chapter show up most often in your classroom, one-student-at-a-time participation, long sitting time, language load, or proximity issues?
2. **Who Is and Isn't Being Served:** During calendar time, who is most engaged and who is least engaged? Do multilingual learners, quieter students, or those with high energy get as many chances to participate as their peers? What is one way you could expand options for them to show what they know?
3. **Student Voice:** If you asked your students to redesign calendar time, what might they change? How could you gather their input this week?

Activities

1. **Audit and Listen:** Over your next three calendar times jot notes on who participates, who zones out, who fidgets, and who struggles with language. Then ask students what their favorite part of calendar is and what feels hardest, using sticky notes or quick check-in cards to capture their answers. Use both sources of information together to identify your most pressing barrier.
2. **Design a Calendar Journal Page:** Create one prototype page that could replace passive watching with active participation. Include options like writing today's date in multiple ways, drawing the weather, and representing the number of the day with tally marks, coins, or drawings. Consider creating two versions, one with more scaffolds and one more open-ended.
3. **Freshen It Up:** Take one routine from your current calendar and brainstorm at least three new ways to do it. Counting days in school could become karate chops, dinosaur stomps, or a student-chosen movement of the week. Then identify one other routine where student voice could shape the content, like asking students what to track this month instead of deciding for them.

Commented [AU3]: create calendar journal resource

Reading, Phonics, and Literacy

Ask Yourself

1. **Your Current Approach:** How is foundational reading instruction currently delivered in your classroom? Is it mostly whole group, small group, or a mix? What barriers have you noticed in terms of pace, engagement, or participation, and which students are those barriers affecting most?
2. **Where Does the Decision Making Live:** Looking at your current phonics block, is it mostly the teacher directing students through the lesson or do students have agency over how and when they move through the learning? What would it look like to shift one decision from your side to theirs?
3. **Design for Your Learners:** How could you use assessment to better understand the range of learners in your classroom? Which of the suggested stations might work best for your students and your space, and what would you need to get one or two of them up and running?

Activities

1. **Redesign for Agency:** Map where decision making currently lives in your phonics block using a simple T-chart with Teacher Decisions on one side and Student Decisions on the other. Identify one whole group routine that could be redesigned to give students more agency, write a brief plan for what it looks like now and what barrier it creates, and describe how you would redesign it to offer more choice or a more flexible pathway.
2. **Design a Self-Sufficient Station:** Choose one phonics station from the chapter and design it with at least three task card options and a challenge card. Think about how a student would know what to do when they arrive without asking you. What materials, visuals, or instructions would make it fully self-sufficient?
3. **Try Gradual Release:** Plan one upcoming phonics lesson using the I do, We do, You do structure and identify the self-assessment moment you will build into each transition. After the lesson reflect on who moved to partner work, who stayed for more modeling, and what that told you. Then design a simple self-assessment tool students could use independently, considering how the environment or a visual could do that work for your youngest learners who are still developing metacognitive skills.

Writing

Ask Yourself

1. **Barriers and Adaptations:** Which barriers to writing show up most frequently in your classroom? Identify one existing resource or routine you could adapt or scaffold this week to better support a wider range of learners, without starting from scratch.
2. **Expanding Choice:** Beyond content choice, what is one new way you could offer choice in the process or product of writing? How could you use gradual release to support students who struggle with idea generation while still giving those who are ready the freedom to begin independently?
3. **Building Persistence:** How might you incorporate the struggle scout idea or other growth mindset strategies into your writing instruction? What would it look like to make productive struggle visible and celebrated in your classroom rather than something students try to hide?

Activity

1. **Build Your Writing Toolkit:** Do a scavenger hunt through your classroom for existing scaffolds and supports like alphabet charts, name tags, anchor charts, and visual checklists. Then fill any gaps by gathering and organizing a writing toolkit that includes different sized pencils and markers, varied paper types, clipboards, lap desks, personal dictionaries, and high frequency word lists. Create two versions of a scaffolded graphic organizer, one with more support and one more open ended, and add both to the toolkit.
2. **Design Your Writing Environment:** Designate two or three writing zones in your classroom, a quiet cozy corner with clipboards, a movement friendly area with standing space or large paper, and a collaborative table. At the same time create a Story Seed Bank by generating open ended story ideas with students on slips of paper or an anchor chart so no one ever faces a blank page without somewhere to start.
3. **Make Struggle Visible:** Create a Struggle Wall or Persistence Path where students' efforts at overcoming writing challenges are celebrated through anonymized examples of revisions, erasures, and problem solving strategies. Introduce it to students as evidence that writing is hard for everyone and that hard work is worth noticing.

Recess

Ask Yourself

1. **Teach Recess Intentionally:** Have you introduced the playground and recess equipment the way you would introduce any other part of your classroom? What strategies could you implement to help students transition effectively from the high energy of recess back to focused learning?
2. **Predict and Advocate:** What are the most predictable barriers your students face during recess? How could you proactively plan to eliminate them, and where do you need to advocate for better equipment, space, or scheduling to make that possible?
3. **Shared Expectations:** How can you establish consistent expectations for recess among all supervising adults? What would it take to get everyone working from the same playbook so students experience recess the same way regardless of who is watching?

Activity

1. **Introduce and Rehearse:** Plan how you would introduce playground equipment and spaces the way you would any classroom material. Then design role-playing experiences around common playground situations, starting by asking students to generate the list of scenarios themselves.
2. **Co-Create with Students:** Work with students to create two shared resources, a list of playground activities that matches your available space and equipment, and signage with shared expectations designed for early childhood students to be posted right where they need it.
3. **Connect with Colleagues:** Reach out to the PE teacher and other adults who supervise your students. Ask them to share games students could play on the playground, align on shared expectations and successful strategies, and make sure everyone working in that space is operating from the same playbook.

Math

Ask Yourself

1. **Your Math Story and Culture:** Reflect on your own relationship with math and how your experiences as a learner influence the way you teach now. What messages, spoken or unspoken, are you sending students about using tools like manipulatives, number lines, or scratch paper? What is one concrete step you could take tomorrow to begin reshaping both your beliefs and your classroom culture around math?
2. **Barriers and Concrete Thinking:** Of the six barriers in this chapter, which two or three are most prevalent in your classroom right now? Review your upcoming lessons and identify where students might be moving too quickly from concrete to abstract. Which lesson would benefit most from adding a concrete or pictorial phase and what materials could you use?
3. **Launch, Explore, Discuss, Apply, Reflect:** Consider one upcoming math lesson. How could you restructure it using this framework? What would change about student engagement, choice, and understanding, and what challenges might you face in implementing it?

Activities

1. **Audit and Enable:** Spend one full math lesson observing and taking notes on which of the six barriers are showing up and for which students. Then designate a space for your Enable Table, gather your current math tools, and introduce it to students using the co-creation process from the chapter. Document what tools students suggest and which ones they actually reach for during the first week.
2. **Design a Full Lesson:** Take an upcoming math standard and design one complete Launch, Explore, Discuss, Apply, Reflect lesson. Create at least three station options for both the Explore and Apply phases ensuring you have concrete, pictorial, and abstract choices. Teach it and reflect on what worked and what you would change.
3. **Build Your Layers of Support:** Identify five to seven key vocabulary words for your current unit and create sentence frames and consistent gestures for each. Teach both explicitly and observe how students use them over the next two weeks. If working with colleagues divide the layers of support work across your team, one person on sentence

frames, another on visuals, another on a menu of strategies anchor chart. If working solo add one layer per month.

4.

Read Alouds and Reading Comprehension

Ask Yourself

1. **Your Reading Story and Your Students' Choice:** How does your own relationship with reading influence the way you teach it? What shifts might you need to make? And how much choice do your students currently have in their reading? What is one way you could increase that within your current constraints?
2. **Your Read Aloud Practice:** When you read aloud, are you consistently modeling and naming the comprehension strategies you use, or do you ping pong from strategy to strategy? What would more intentional read aloud planning look like for you?
3. **Barriers and Next Steps:** Which barriers from the chapter do most of your students face during reading time? If you could implement just one strategy this week, which would have the biggest impact and what would you need to do to make it happen?

Activities

1. **Strengthen Your Read Aloud:** For your next three read alouds write down beforehand what comprehension skill you are modeling, what you will pause to notice or ask, and how you will make your thinking visible. During one of those read alouds give students whiteboards and ask them to sketch what they picture in their minds during a descriptive passage. Have a few students share their sketches and reflect on whether the combination of planning and visualization changed student engagement.
2. **Support Every Reader:** Choose one upcoming required text or shared reading experience and design at least two supports to help all students access it. This might mean pre-teaching three to five key vocabulary words with visuals before reading, offering an audio version alongside the print version, providing a simple graphic organizer to capture characters, setting, or key ideas, or chunking the text with index cards so it feels less overwhelming. Then offer at least two response formats so students can show their thinking in the way that works best for them, writing, sketching, back to back partner sharing, or speech to text. Reflect on which supports made the biggest

difference and which students you were able to reach that you might not have otherwise.

3. **Build Your Reading System:** Choose one approach to implement over the next quarter. Option A is creating a community of readers by building a classroom library organized around genres, topics, and student interests rather than levels, creating regular opportunities for students to talk about books, and establishing daily independent reading time starting with ten minutes and building stamina. Option B is designing choice based literacy stations by auditing your curriculum and piloting two or three stations with built in choice. Option C is planning a UDL reading unit by choosing a required text, pre-teaching key vocabulary, providing audio support, and mapping scaffolds and response format options before implementing and reflecting on impact. Whichever you choose, add one additional component when you feel ready.

Closing Circle and Dismissal

Ask Yourself

1. **Your End of Day Reality:** What barriers currently prevent a consistent Closing Circle and how does the end of your day typically feel for both you and your students? What would regulated, restored, and storing away their learnings actually look and feel like in your classroom? What is one small step you could take this week to carve out time for it?
2. **Choosing Your Approach:** Which Closing Circle activities resonate most with you and your students? Which students might find the transition home most challenging and how could elements like predictability, calm activities, or mindfulness moments specifically support them as they leave your care each day?
3. **Morning and Closing as Bookends:** How could your Morning Meeting and Closing Circle mirror or complement each other to create a sense of completeness? What elements could open and close the day in a way that feels symmetrical and caring, a greeting that echoes the goodbye, a song that bookends the day, a community ritual that signals both beginning and end?

Activities

1. **Design and Troubleshoot:** Create a two column chart listing the barriers that currently prevent an effective Closing Circle and one concrete strategy to address each. Then use that thinking to design your routine, mapping out a 5 to 10 minute structure with a greeting, activity, and goodbye, choosing two or three activities to rotate through the week, and identifying when in your schedule it will live. Write it down and commit to trying it for one week.
2. **Build Your Activity Menu:** Create a visual reference of eight to ten Closing Circle activities organized by type, songs, games, goodbyes and gratitude, mindfulness, and brief reflection. For each note what it requires, when it works best, and any adaptations for your students. Then try the photo documentation approach for one full day, selecting five to eight images at the end of the day to use as reflection prompts in your Closing Circle. Note how students respond to visual prompts compared to verbal ones alone.
3. **Connect Morning and Closing:** Review your Morning Meeting routine and identify three to five elements that could bookend your day. If you sing good morning at the start could you sing goodbye friends at the end? If you pass a greeting around the circle in the morning could you pass gratitude at closing? Map out the parallel structures and try implementing one this week.

